

Vajra-Mushti Yuddha: The Legacy of Forgotten Warriors

Vajra-mushti yuddha represents one of the most radical and violent expressions of pre-modern Indian martial arts. Emerging from the crucible of *malla-yuddha*, traditional Indian wrestling, it combines the use of a reinforced fist weapon with a comprehensive combat system encompassing strikes, throws, joint locks, and prolonged phases of ground fighting. Medieval textual sources such as Someswara III's *Manasollasa* and the *Malla Purana*, attributed to the Jyesthimalla lineages, attest that these practices were neither marginal nor improvised but rather rigorously codified, both technically and ritually.

In its early form, vajra-mushti yuddha differed fundamentally from later sportive or ceremonial practices by the absence of rules limiting the intensity of confrontation. The weapon—generally crafted from buffalo horn, ivory, or occasionally metal—could be simple or fitted with discreet spikes designed to concentrate impact on vulnerable areas of the body. Combat permitted close-range striking, the use of the free hand to seize, off-balance, or throw the opponent, as well as the continuation of the fight on the ground until complete neutralization. Such neutralization could take the form of explicit submission, clear physical incapacitation, or, in some documented cases, the death of the combatant.

The historical transition toward ritualized forms, such as the *Vajra Mushti Kalaga* of Mysore incorporated into the Dasara celebrations, marks a gradual process of de-escalation of violence. Under the influence of political, religious, and colonial transformations, the public practice of vajra-mushti was progressively regulated, softened, and ultimately converted into cultural heritage. However, this visible evolution does not preclude the hypothesis of a subterranean continuity. Several anthropologists and martial arts historians have suggested that certain Indian warrior traditions survived by deliberately withdrawing from the public sphere, transmitting their knowledge within closed, often familial circles.

From this perspective, vajra-mushti yuddha may have persisted as a clandestine discipline, preserved by descendants of ancient wrestling lineages—sometimes identified as Jyesthimalla—or by groups affiliated with the guardianship of temples, shrines, or former princely domains. These groups would have maintained the oral transmission of techniques, implicit combat rules, and opening and closing rituals, while adapting their practices to the necessity of invisibility. Training and combat sites would thus lie outside tourist and urban circuits, in abandoned forts, forest enclosures, caves, or semi-ruined structures inherited from the medieval period.

The ritual framework of these clandestine encounters would retain fundamental importance. Prior to combat, participants would perform purification gestures inspired by ancient treatises, including oil anointments, breathing postures, and invocations intended to strengthen concentration and endurance. The weapon itself would be treated as a liminal object, both a tool of combat and a symbol of lineage, sometimes transmitted from master to disciple. Combat would begin only after mutual recognition of the opponent's legitimacy—a crucial condition within a system where violence is perceived as a test of worth rather than mere entertainment.

On a technical level, this surviving form of vajra-mushti yuddha would be characterized by an integrated approach to combat. Strikes would primarily target vital points (*marman*), clavicles, temples, or joints, while throws would be used to break the opponent's bodily structure and bring them to the ground. Ground fighting, far from being incidental, would constitute a decisive phase, during which the armed fist would be employed at very close range, combined with elbow, knee, or cervical joint locks. This combination of targeted violence and physical control echoes ancient descriptions of *yuddha* as total combat, demanding absolute mastery of both body and mind.